CINI Ethical Engagement & Funding Acceptance Policy

Child in Need Institute (CINI) has always stood for the dignity, health, and rights of women, children, and marginalized communities. As the landscape of funding and partnerships becomes increasingly complex, this Ethical Engagement Policy provides clarity and structure to ensure that CINI's actions are consistent with our mission, that our reputation remains protected, and that our partnerships strengthen—rather than compromise—the trust communities place in us.

Purpose and Scope

This policy sets out CINI's standards, exclusions, and procedures for engaging with private sector entities, corporate donors, philanthropic arms of companies, and other organizations that may provide funding, sponsorship, donations, or technical collaboration.

Uphold Vision & Mission

Protect and promote the rights of children, women, and marginalized communities.

Safeguard Public Health

Ensure partnerships support nutrition, gender equality, and social protection goals.

Avoid Risks

Prevent reputational, ethical, or operational risks from partnerships with industries whose practices contradict CINI's values.

Align with Global Standards

Follow guidance from the United Nations, WHO, UNICEF, and key advocacy networks.

This policy applies to all forms of engagement, including cash or in-kind donations, CSR contributions, joint activities, sponsorships, and technical collaborations.

Core Principles

Protection of Public Health & Child Rights

No collaboration should undermine health promotion, nutrition, child protection, or education.

Independence & Integrity

CINI retains autonomy in program design, implementation, evaluation, and advocacy.

Avoidance of Conflicts of Interest

Partnerships must not allow corporate entities to influence policies, advocacy, or norm-setting in areas such as nutrition, breastfeeding, or environmental protection.

Human Rights Due Diligence

CINI applies the UN Guiding Principles on Business & Human Rights and the Children's Rights & Business Principles in screening partners.

Alignment with International Norms

CINI follows WHO's Framework of Engagement with Non-State Actors, WHO Framework Convention on Tobacco Control, International Code of Marketing of Breast-Milk Substitutes, and relevant Indian laws.

Red-Line Exclusions: Absolute Prohibitions

CINI will not accept funds, in-kind support, or enter into partnerships with entities engaged in the following sectors or practices. These prohibitions are absolute and non-negotiable.

Tobacco

Examples: ITC, Philip Morris, Godfrey Phillips

Rationale: WHO FCTC Article 5.3 prohibits partnerships; tobacco industry is fundamentally incompatible with public health.

Alcohol

Examples: United Breweries, Diageo, Pernod Ricard

Rationale: Major contributor to NCDs, injuries, and addiction; UNICEF and leading INGOs exclude alcohol funding.

Gambling & Betting

Examples: Flutter, Dream11, Bet365

Rationale: Associated with addiction, debt, exploitation, and child-risk; excluded in UNICEF USA gift-acceptance policies.

Additional prohibited sectors include arms & ammunition, pornography, breast-milk substitutes violating the International Code, ultra-processed foods & sugary beverages, environmental violators, human rights violators, and entities linked to terrorism financing or criminal networks.

More Red-Line Exclusions

Breast-Milk Substitutes (BMS) Violators

Examples: Nestlé, Danone, Mead Johnson

Rationale: Breaches International Code, WHA Resolutions, and India's IMS Act; undermines breastfeeding and child nutrition.

Ultra-Processed Foods & Sugary Beverages

Examples: Coca-Cola, PepsiCo, McDonald's, KFC

Rationale: Linked to obesity, diabetes, and poor diets; WHO guidance warns against involvement of these industries in child-nutrition policy.

Environmental Violators

Examples: ExxonMobil, Shell, Coal India, loggers linked to deforestation

Rationale: Heavy carbon emitters, polluters, or deforesters without verified transition plans; incompatible with sustainability.

For the Indian context, the IMS Act (1992, amended 2003) bans sponsorship, promotion, and marketing of infant milk substitutes and feeding bottles. The COTPA Act prohibits partnerships with tobacco companies. Screening against Government of India, UN, and FATF-sanctions lists is mandatory to prevent links to terrorism or illicit networks.

Discouraged Engagement (Grey Zones)

Not all companies fall into "red-line" exclusions. However, there are cases where engagement presents serious ethical or reputational risks even if not absolutely prohibited. These are classified as grey zones. By default, CINI will avoid these partnerships — but in exceptional cases, they may be considered under strict review and safeguards.

Mixed-Portfolio Food & Beverage Companies

Examples: Unilever, Nestlé (beyond BMS products), PepsiCo, ITC Foods

Risk: These corporations may produce some socially beneficial products but are also major promoters of ultra-processed foods, sugary drinks, and child-targeted marketing.

Default stance: Decline funding and branding opportunities.

Alcohol-Linked Philanthropic Foundations

Examples: "Responsibility" initiatives sponsored by Diageo or AB InBev

Risk: These are often front-groups used to weaken regulation or improve corporate image.

Default stance: Decline funding and formal engagement.

Transitioning Industries

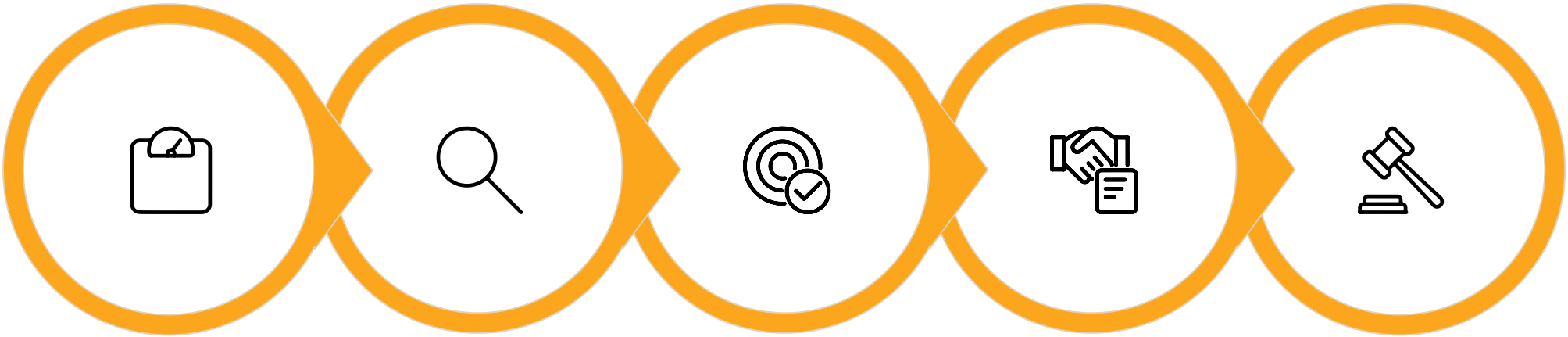
Examples: Fossil fuel companies claiming to diversify into renewable energy, or mining companies pledging "responsible sourcing."

Risk: Engagement may be used as greenwashing while core harmful activities continue.

Default stance: Decline partnerships unless transition is independently verified and harmful activities are being phased out.

Principle for Grey Zones: If doubt exists, CINI prioritises long-term credibility and community trust over short-term funding.

Process to Handle Ethically Sensitive CSR Offers



Ethical Framework | **Due Diligence** | **Mission Alignment** | **Assess Intent** | **Governance Refer**

Some CSR offers may not clearly violate CINI's red-line exclusions but still raise concerns. These are classified as ethically sensitive offers. To protect CINI's mission, such offers must be assessed through an established and transparent process.

All assessments must be consistent with this Ethical Funding Policy. Decisions must be documented, reviewed, and justified. Final decisions prioritise CINI's values, reputation, and long-term credibility over short-term funding.

More Steps in Handling Sensitive CSR Offers

1 Public Perception Check

Apply the "front-page test": If the partnership was reported on the front page of a national newspaper, would it enhance or damage CINI's credibility?

Seek feedback, where necessary, from trusted community partners or donor allies.

2 Decision-Making

Decline if risks outweigh benefits or if intent is reputational/image-washing.

Approve with safeguards only if risks are manageable, with strict conditions written into MoUs.

Approve only when no conflicts exist and the partnership clearly advances CINI's mission.

3 Communicate Transparently

Inform internal staff, stakeholders, and (if necessary) communities about decisions.

Rejections should be explained as value-driven decisions, not arbitrary refusals.

4 Prioritise Long-Term Credibility

Always prioritise community trust, donor confidence, and CINI's independence over short-term financial gains.

Every sensitive offer must be logged in CINI's Ethical Engagement Register. Decisions must record reasons for acceptance/rejection, safeguards applied, and date of review and sign-off.

Due Diligence Workflow

CINI conducts mandatory due diligence on every prospective partner, donor, or CSR contributor before entering into any form of engagement. This ensures that risks are identified early and that CINI's mission, reputation, and community trust are protected.

Red-Line Screening

Immediate check against CINI's red-line exclusions. If triggered → automatic decline.

Identity & Integrity Checks

Verify legal entity registration, beneficial ownership, and corporate structure. Screen against UN Sanctions List, FATF lists, and Government of India banned entities.

Human Rights Screening

Review policies and track record on child labour, gender equality, worker rights, and indigenous rights.

Environmental & ESG Assessment

Review company's environmental record and ESG ratings. Identify risk of greenwashing.

Public Health Conflict of Interest Assessment

For food, beverage, alcohol, or nutrition-linked industries, apply WHO/PAHO COI Assessment Tool.

Mandatory Safeguards

No Policy Influence

Partners may not influence CINI's advocacy, policy positions, or research outputs. CINI will not allow commercial entities to participate in policy or norm-setting forums through its platforms.

Branding and Recognition Rules

Donor acknowledgement must never overshadow the cause or community. Co-branding is prohibited for sensitive sectors. Use of CINI's name or logo in product marketing is strictly forbidden.

Compliance with Codes and Laws

All partners must comply with the International Code of Marketing of Breast-Milk Substitutes, India's IMS Act, WHO FCTC provisions, and Child Labour Act. Breach of any of these = immediate termination.

Data Protection and Privacy

Donors may not access beneficiary-level or identifiable data. Only anonymised, aggregate reporting is permitted. Data sharing for commercial purposes is prohibited.

Even when a partner or donor is rated Green (acceptable) or Amber (conditional), CINI must apply these mandatory safeguards. These conditions protect CINI from undue influence, ensure compliance with international norms, and safeguard beneficiaries and communities.

More Mandatory Safeguards

Transparency and Disclosure

CINI will publicly disclose the name of donor/partner, purpose and value of contribution, and duration of engagement. Exceptions only in cases where security or privacy risks exist.

Right to Audit, Suspend, and Terminate

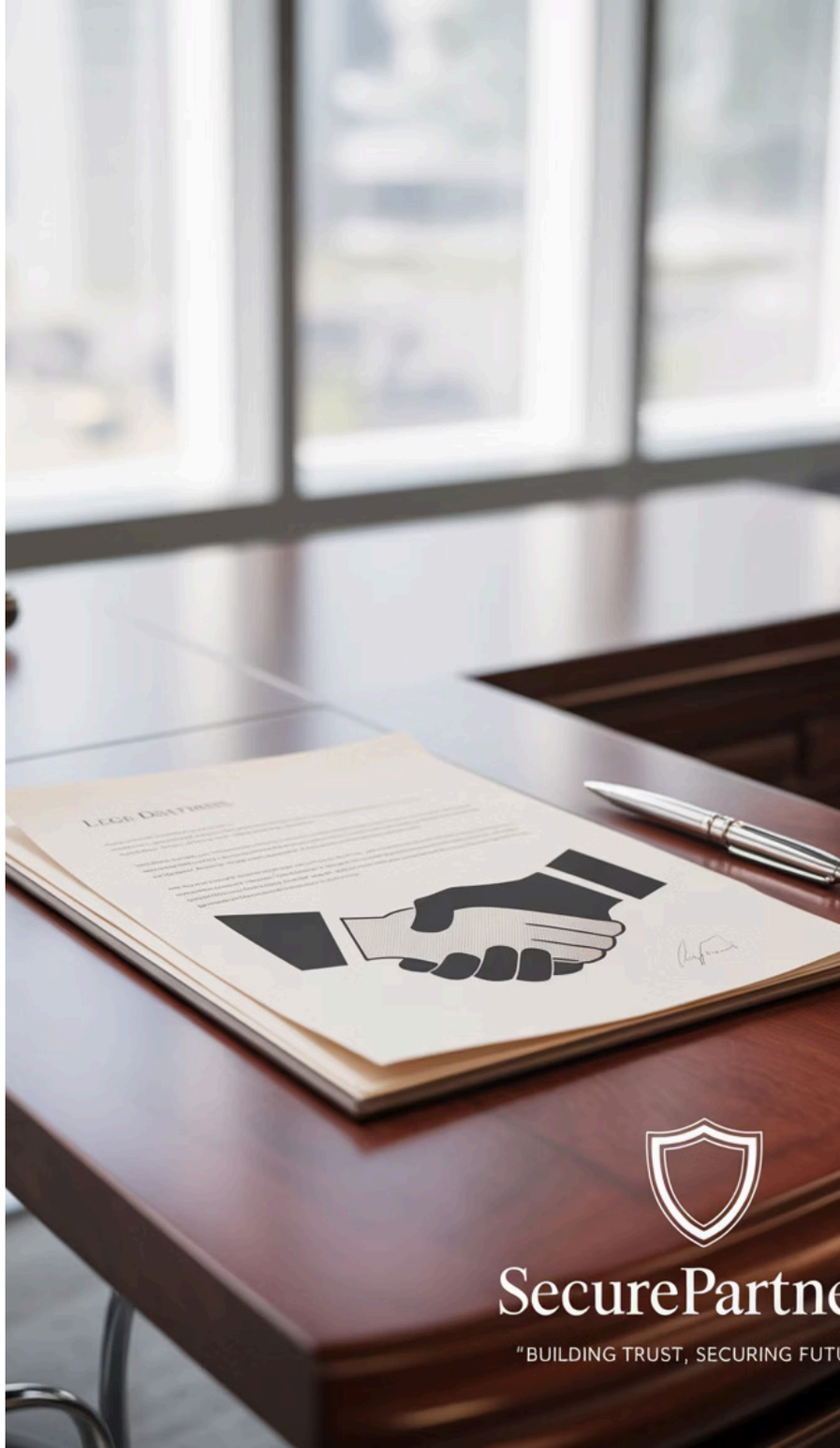
CINI reserves the unilateral right to audit donor compliance, suspend or terminate partnerships if new information reveals conflicts or violations. All agreements must include a termination clause.

Safeguards for Grey-Zone Partnerships

For partnerships rated Amber, additional clauses must be inserted into MoUs, including independent monitoring mechanisms, restrictions on branding, and prohibition of policy involvement.

Community Safeguards

Beneficiaries' dignity, rights, and well-being remain at the centre of every engagement. Communities must never be exploited for corporate image-building.



Governance & Accountability

Strong governance is essential for ensuring that CINI's Ethical Engagement & Funding Acceptance Policy is applied consistently, fairly, and transparently across all programs and partnerships.

Institutional Oversight

- Governing Board provides ultimate oversight and approves the policy
- Executive Director is responsible for institutional compliance
- Board reviews annual reports on implementation

Ethics & Partnerships Committee (EPC)

- Includes Board member, senior program leader, legal expert, and child rights expert
- Reviews ethically sensitive or "Amber-rated" cases
- Ensures decisions align with mission and values
- Maintains a Decision Log documenting outcomes

Quality Assurance & Risk Management

- Integrates ethical funding into overall risk framework
- Conducts compliance checks
- Collaborates with program teams on due diligence

Transparency Mechanisms

- Annual disclosure of all private sector donors
- Summary of ethical engagement in annual report
- Staff training and awareness programs
- Whistleblowing and accountability systems

Linkages with Other CINI Policies

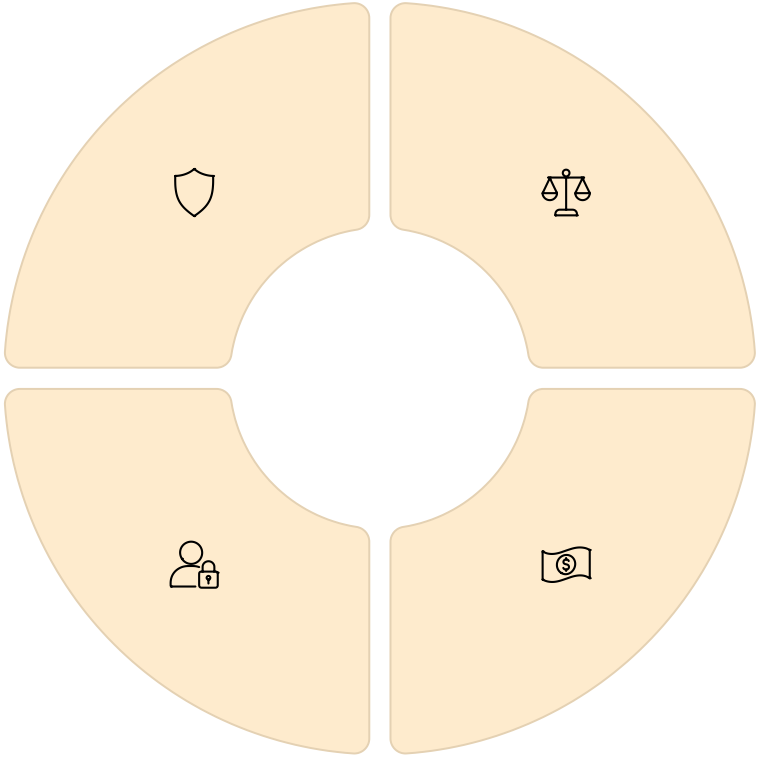
CINI recognizes that ethical engagement cannot exist in isolation. It is part of the wider institutional culture of accountability, transparency, and rights-based programming. Therefore, this Ethical Engagement Policy is explicitly linked to CINI's existing policies, frameworks, and committees.

Child Protection Policy

CSR funds must not originate from entities engaged in child labour or exploitation. Child protection principles supersede all financial considerations.

Gender and Diversity Policy

Donor partnerships must reflect gender equity principles. Association with companies with a record of gender-based harassment shall be disallowed.



Data Protection Policy

Prevents donors from accessing sensitive data of beneficiaries without consent. Protects CINI from pressures to share personal data.

Finance & Audit Policy

Ensures transparent recording of accepted/rejected funds. All CSR offers must be logged in the Ethical Funding Register.

Ethical Screening Tool

The Ethical Screening Tool enables CINI to systematically assess prospective donors, CSR funders, and partners against its Ethical Funding Policy. It safeguards alignment with CINI's vision, mission, and values, while ensuring that funding sources do not contradict thematic priorities.

1

Screening Categories

- Alignment with CINI's Values
- Excluded Industries
- Environmental Practices
- Human Rights Practices
- Terror/Illegal Funding

2

Decision Rules

- No Red Flags → Proceed with proposal
- 1 Red Flag → Escalate to Ethics Committee
- 2+ Red Flags → Recommend rejection

3

Integration with Systems

- Tool digitized and integrated into CINI's Proposal Management System
- AI-enabled donor vetting can query the Redline Database
- Results linked to donor records

This tool turns policy into a practical instrument, allowing staff to identify risks early, document decisions, ensure transparency in donor selection, and maintain consistency across all fundraising actions.

Redline Register (Restricted Entity Database)

The Redline Register is CINI's central repository of restricted entities – companies, foundations, or individuals with whom partnership, funding, or engagement is not permitted due to ethical, legal, or reputational risks. It serves as a living database to guide decision-making and safeguard CINI's credibility.

Who Maintains It

- Primary Custodian: Partnerships & Resource Mobilization Unit
- Validation: Ethics Committee reviews new entries and approves removals
- Oversight: Board Governance & Quality Assurance team

When to Use

- During the screening stage of a new proposal or engagement
- During annual donor review
- Whenever new intelligence emerges

The register includes entity name, sector, nature of concern, source of evidence, date added, review date, decision (Reject/Escalate/Removed), and remarks. It is updated immediately upon new risk identification, reviewed quarterly by the Partnerships team, and validated annually by the Ethics Committee.

Due Diligence Checklist

1 Legal & Compliance

Is the organisation compliant with national laws, FCRA, tax rules, and UN sanctions lists?

2 Business Practices

Has the organisation been implicated in child labour, forced labour, corruption, bribery, or unfair trade practices?

3 Alignment with CINI Values

Does the organisation's core business conflict with CINI's mission (e.g., tobacco, infant formula, alcohol, fossil fuels, arms)?

4 Environmental & Social Governance (ESG)

Does the organisation publish sustainability/CSR reports, adhere to ESG standards, and avoid environmental degradation?

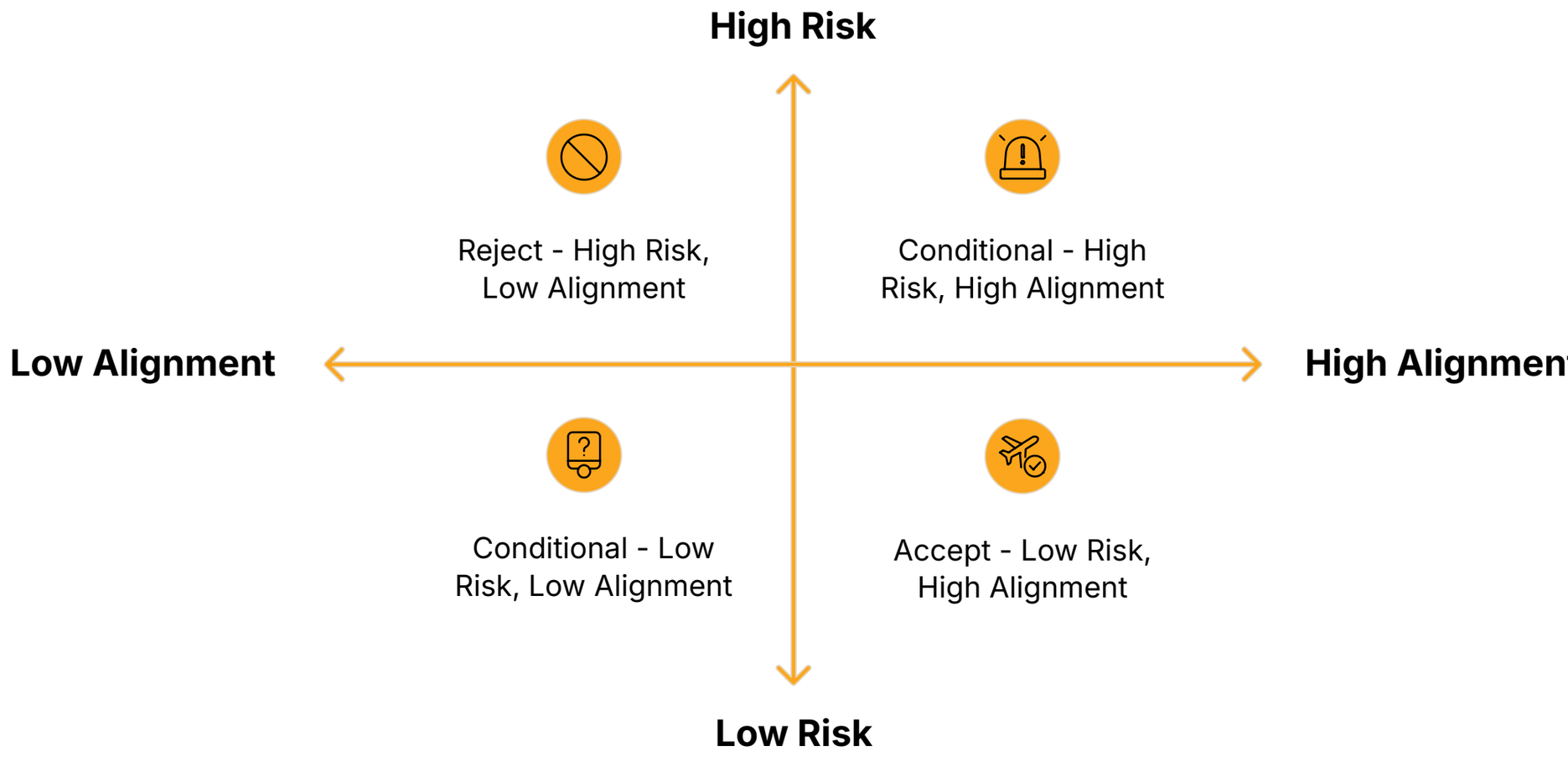
5 Reputation & Public Perception

Are there major media scandals, advocacy campaigns, or community concerns about this organisation?

While the Redline Register identifies entities already classified as prohibited, many potential CSR partners or donors may not be on that list but still require thorough review. The Due Diligence Checklist ensures that CINI evaluates every prospective engagement against ethical, legal, and reputational benchmarks before entering into agreements.

Ethical Funding Decision Matrix

The Due Diligence Checklist generates evidence about a potential partner or donor. The Ethical Funding Decision Matrix is the next step, helping CINI assess that evidence systematically and decide whether to accept, accept with caution, or reject.



The matrix assigns weighted scores across key domains: Business Sector, Legal & Compliance, Human Rights & Labour, Environmental Impact, Reputation, and Intent & Conditions. Each domain is scored 1 (Low Risk) to 3 (High Risk). The total determines the decision band:

- **Go (Accept):** Total score ≤ 7 → Partner acceptable with normal monitoring.
- **Caution (Conditional):** Score 8–12 → Partner may be accepted with conditions, stronger oversight, and ethics approval.
- **No-Go (Reject):** Score ≥ 13 → Partner must not be accepted.

Communication & Transparency Tools

Transparency is central to ensuring that CINI's ethical funding framework is trusted by staff, donors, communities, and the public. These tools and templates ensure ethical decisions are communicated clearly, donor relationships are managed diplomatically, and internal alignment is maintained.

Internal Communication Note

To inform staff of an ethics-based funding decision, including the company name, decision (declined/accepted), and reference to specific criteria/redline.

Donor Rejection Letter

To diplomatically reject offers from redlined/ethically misaligned companies, explaining that decisions are based on alignment with CINI's mission and values.

Donor Acceptance & Conditions Letter

To set clear boundaries where engagement is ethically sensitive but permissible with conditions, such as unrestricted funding, no branding that implies endorsement, and reference to CINI's independence.

Public Disclosure Note

For Annual Report/Website, summarizing the number of donor engagements reviewed, accepted with conditions, and declined based on redline criteria.

Training & Capacity-Building Framework

Policies and tools are only effective if staff are aware, trained, and capable of applying them in real decision-making. This framework ensures that every team member understands CINI's Ethical Engagement Policy, screening tools, and reporting systems.

1

Orientation Module for New Staff

Half-day training covering CINI's Mission & Values, Ethical Funding Policy overview, Redline Database demonstration, case studies, and reporting procedures.

2

Annual Refresher Training

1-day workshop focusing on updates to redline criteria, review of recent case studies, group exercise on "grey-zone" decisions, and peer-to-peer discussion on challenges faced.

3

Specialized Training for Leadership

Every 2 years, covering global trends in ethical philanthropy and CSR, legal compliance updates, navigating stakeholder pushback, and complex donor scenarios.

4

Partner & Community Awareness

As needed, especially for new community projects involving CSR donors, using simplified community leaflets, orientation sessions, and storytelling/role-play.

Training materials include slide decks explaining ethical engagement, handouts with quick reference guides, posters/infographics, and case study booklets with global and Indian examples of ethical dilemmas.

Monitoring, Review & Continuous Improvement

Policies remain effective only if they are monitored, reviewed, and adapted to evolving contexts. CINI ensures that the Ethical Engagement Policy and related tools are not static documents but are continuously updated in line with emerging ethical risks, feedback from staff and stakeholders, lessons learned from actual donor interactions, and changes in compliance frameworks.

Regular monitoring includes quarterly compliance reports, database tracking, and case logbooks. Internal audits verify consistent application of tools, documentation of decisions, and staff training. Every 3 years, an external ethics or compliance expert reviews the policy and practices.

The review cycle includes annual policy reviews by the Ethics Committee, mid-year adjustments for urgent updates, and a five-year strategic review aligning with international standards. Continuous improvement mechanisms include feedback loops, learning from cases, benchmarking with peer NGOs, and adoption of AI-enabled tools.